

Socialism

1. Socialists care a lot about how individuals, the government, and society relate to each other. They think people should think about their actions in relation to others.
2. Socialists don't agree with liberals and conservatives who say people are naturally selfish. Instead, they think selfishness is learned through capitalism. They believe that in a socialist society, people would be more cooperative and caring.
3. Socialists think the way an economy works is super important. They didn't like how industrial capitalism treated people, so they wanted a different kind of economy based on different values.
4. Some early socialists like Robert Owen wanted to change capitalism, while others like Karl Marx wanted to completely replace it with socialism. Nowadays, socialists often see it as a gradual change that takes market forces into account.
5. The word "socialism" first popped up in Italy in 1803, but it didn't mean what it does today. It was used later to describe people who believed in a more social-focused way of organizing society, in contrast to those who really liked individualism and laissez-faire economics

Industrial Revolution and the Rise of Socialism

Socialism developed as a response to the problems caused by the Industrial Revolution in the 1800s. During this period, industrialization drastically changed people's lives, especially for the working class. British politics in the 1830s started to address these issues, such as the harsh conditions in textile factories, which were revealed in the Sadler Committee's Report in 1832. These reports showed how unregulated industrial growth had terrible effects on human lives. Additionally, new technologies in the workplace led to job losses and made workers feel disconnected from their work. Some people, known as Utopian socialists, believed that these problems could be prevented and sought to create a better society.

Utopian Socialists: Owen, Saint-Simon, Fourier

At the beginning of socialism, there were three main groups: Fourierists and Saint-Simonians in France, and Owenites in Britain. They all agreed that solving social issues and promoting general well-being were crucial. They didn't like the idea of a society where people compete for resources. Instead, they believed in cooperation and giving control to the "producers" rather than politicians.

But these groups had differences too. Fourierists and Owenites wanted to create experimental communities based on their ideas. Saint-Simonians, on the other hand, believed in large organizations and scientific planning. They thought nations should be like big corporations run by scientists and technicians. Unlike the other two, they were okay with using politics to make their ideas a reality.

So, early socialism was about working together to make society better, with a focus on wealth distribution and not so much on politics. They believed in education to shape people's behavior and attitudes. Importantly, they didn't see a conflict between the rich and the working class or believe in a revolution.

Scientific socialism

The modern socialist movement started when Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels wrote the Communist Manifesto in 1848. They used the term "communism," which is similar to socialism but more radical. The Manifesto talked about how society changes due to economic factors and how the working class (proletariat) would eventually lead a revolution to create a classless society called communism.

Marx and Engels believed that the working class, because of their difficult lives under capitalism, would become the leaders of this change. They saw the state as serving the rich and powerful and thought the working class would take control, leading to communism.

The Manifesto had a strong message about class struggle and revolution, which made it important, even though it didn't predict everything accurately. It gave a sense of purpose to history, saying that progress comes through struggle and revolution.

Socialism during its "Mature" Phase

Socialism became important in the 19th century alongside the rise of liberalism in Europe. By 1889, socialism started challenging liberalism's dominance in politics. Different types of socialist thinking emerged during this time, with Marxism being the most influential. This shift towards socialism was influenced by the idea of using scientific knowledge to understand society, inspired by thinkers like Auguste Comte and Herbert Spencer. Marx claimed that his socialism was scientific. The role of the state in society also changed, as laissez-faire policies failed, and people turned to the government for help.

Factors like increasing urbanization, rising literacy, and more democratic elections contributed to the growth of socialism, creating a basis for worker consciousness and socialist movements.

The Spread of Marxism during 1880s

During the 19th century, socialism took various forms, but Marxism became popular in countries with large industrial working-class populations like France, Germany, and Belgium. However, in places with less industrialization like Spain, anarchism was prominent among both workers and peasants. Anarchism also had a following in Italy but not as large as in Spain. In Russia, Marxism gained importance later and didn't dominate the socialist movement.

Friedrich Engels worked to make Marx's theories more accessible, emphasizing that Marxism was not just a revolutionary idea but a scientific worldview. He defended Marx's ideas in works like "Anti-Dühring" and focused on the materialist conception of history. Engels believed that socialism was an inevitable historical process, and this idea appealed to socialists in the late 19th century, especially during the height of positivism. Figures like Karl Kautsky, Eduard Bernstein, Georgy Plekhanov, and V. I. Lenin were influenced by Engels's elaboration of Marxist doctrine. Engels's materialist view of history became a fundamental belief in the regimes that identified as Marxist in the 20th century.

The Anarchist Alternative

Anarchism was a significant part of the socialist movement in the 19th and early 20th centuries, and it often clashed with Marxism. While there were various branches of anarchism, they all opposed Marxism mainly due to their different views on the role of the state. Marxists believed the state was necessary temporarily, but anarchists rejected it entirely.

Anarchists also disagreed with Marxism's communist principles, thinking they would lead to an authoritarian society. They believed that workers should focus on creating their own social structures and engaging in economic struggles rather than seizing political power.

Anarchists didn't participate in politics and preferred direct action tactics like strikes, sabotage, and public demonstrations. Some resorted to violence, which led to a stereotype of anarchists as extremists trying to destroy society. However, most anarchists opposed terrorism, focusing on education and trade unions for their revolutionary activities.

At the turn of the century, anarchism saw a revival with the development of revolutionary syndicalism, which combined trade unionism with anarchist ideas, leading to the growth of anarcho-syndicalism,

especially in France, Spain, and Italy. In Spain, it became a mass movement, with millions of members during the Spanish Civil War.

Marxism Challenged

Towards the end of the 19th century, there were different socialist ideas challenging Marxism. One significant one was Fabianism, which became prominent in Great Britain after 1889. The Fabian Society was initially made up of upper-middle-class intellectuals like George Bernard Shaw, Annie Besant, Beatrice Webb, and Sidney Webb.

Fabianism was different from Marxism. While Marxists believed in class conflict driving historical progress, Fabians saw society evolving gradually, like an organism. They believed in a peaceful, gradual approach to socialism guided by enlightened thinkers. They thought a "scientific" study of society would lead to an effective plan for achieving socialism without revolution. This set them apart from Marxists who saw social change as a dialectical struggle.

Revisionist Controversy on the Continent

In the late 1800s, some socialist thinkers began challenging traditional Marxism. Eduard Bernstein, a German social democrat, was a key figure in this revisionist movement. He questioned Marx's ideas about class conflict and believed workers were actually improving their living standards. He also thought socialism should benefit everyone, not just workers, which went against some Marxists.

This led to debates within the socialist movement, with figures like Karl Kautsky and Georgy Plekhanov defending traditional Marxism. They believed socialism would come from growing class divisions, not just worsening conditions for workers.

However, despite these debates, many socialist groups were already pursuing more peaceful, reformist approaches. They preferred using the ballot box and working with middle-class parties rather than confrontational tactics. This shift was seen in countries like France, Spain, Italy, and Germany.

Some thinkers, like Georges Sorel, rejected both traditional Marxism and reformism. Sorel embraced revolutionary syndicalism, which emphasized the importance of rebellion and strikes against capitalism. His ideas contributed to the development of left-wing syndicalism across Europe.